# Damaged Products and Damaged-in-Transit Policy

ShopSphere Retail - all categories

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| **Policy ID** | POL-DMG-2024-04 |
| **Version** | 1.5 |
| **Effective date** | 2025-02-01 |
| **Applicable category** | all (electronics, fashion, home_appliances, accessories) |
| **Return window (days)** | Report within 2 days (48 hours) of delivery |
| **Policy owner** | Returns Policy Office with Logistics Claims |
| **Review cycle** | Annual, or earlier on regulatory change |

## 1. Purpose and scope

This policy covers products that arrive damaged, and products damaged in transit on the return leg. It applies across all categories and works alongside the category return policies.

## 2. Reporting window and photographs

- Customers should report visible damage within 48 hours of delivery.
- Photographs are required of: the outer carton (all sides), the shipping label, the inner packaging, and the damaged product.
- Reports received after 48 hours are still reviewed, but the case is routed for manual investigation and the supporting evidence must be stronger.

## 3. Delivery records

The delivery partner records exceptions on the delivery scan (deliveries.delivery_issue). A recorded delivery issue such as a crushed carton is strong supporting evidence for a damage claim but does not replace the warehouse inspection. Investigators must cite both the delivery record and the inspection findings. A delivery_dispute investigation case is opened where the carrier claim is contested.

## 4. Responsibility

- Customers are not charged for damage caused by the carrier.
- ShopSphere files a claim with the logistics partner within 7 days of the inspection confirming transit damage.
- If inspection finds no damage consistent with the claim, the outcome is recorded as additional verification required and the customer is contacted for further photographs.

## 5. Return-leg damage

If a product is damaged during reverse pickup, the pickup agent's condition notes and photographs are compared with the warehouse inspection. Return-leg damage is never deducted from the customer's refund.

## 6. Refund approval thresholds

| Refund amount | Approver | Notes |
|---|---|---|
| Up to INR 10,000 | Returns analyst | Every refund raised by the returns investigation assistant needs a human approval before execution. |
| INR 10,000.01 to INR 50,000 | Returns supervisor | Analyst recommendation plus supervisor sign-off. |
| Above INR 50,000 | Returns supervisor and Finance controller | Dual approval; inspection report must be attached. |

| Refund amount | Approver | Notes |
|---|---|---|
| Any amount with an open investigation case | Returns supervisor | Refund is held until the case is resolved. |

## 7. Refund rules

- A return may have at most one completed refund. Before any refund is requested, the refunds ledger must be checked; if a completed refund already exists for the return_id, no further refund may be requested or executed.
- Refunds are issued to the original payment method within 5-7 business days of approval. Store credit is issued only when the customer selects it.
- Refund amounts may not exceed the unit price paid on the order line (order_items.unit_price), excluding any promotional cashback already reversed.